

Fig. Epilogue 3: Sculpture of Ashoka at Kalinga by Meera Mukherjee

For all we know, if knowledge of Ashoka's words had survived in all their nuances—as did the memory of Ashoka's Buddhist avatara—he may have been remembered as the founder of a unique political model of humane governance, one which would have been closer to the historical emperor. But in this respect the afterlife of Ashoka, like his real life, remains poised between legend and the truth.